UNIT 14

The Mughal Empire

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Learning Objectives

To acquaint oneself with

- Foundation of Mughal rule in India
- Humayun's inability to sustain his rule leading to the establishment of Sur dynasty under Sher Shah
- Sher Shah's administrative reforms
- Consolidation of Mughal rule during the reign of Akbar
- Akbar's Religious and Rajput policy
- Significance of Jahangir's rule
- Shah Jahan's contribution to art and architecture
- Aurangzeb's military conquests and his ruinous Rajput and Deccan policies and his wars against the Marathas
- India during Mughal rule: Development of literature, painting, music, architecture; Bhakti Movement, Sufism Sikhism, spread of Christianity and Islam, trade, commerce, industry, science and technology

Introduction

India had been invaded from the west/ north-west several times over the centuries, beginning with Alexander. Various parts of north India had been ruled by foreigners like the Indo-Greeks, Sakas, Kushans and Afghans. The Mughals, descended from the Mongol Chengiz Khan and the Turk Timur, founded an empire in India which lasted for more than three centuries. But we remember them not as rulers of foreign origin, but as an indigenous, Indian dynasty. Babur was the founder of the Mughal empire which was established in 1526 after Babur defeated Ibrahim Lodi in the battle of Panipat. Thus a new epoch and a new empire in India began, lasting for nearly three centuries beginning from 1526 to 1857. Six major rulers of this dynasty, Babur, Humayun, Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb, known as the "Great Mughals", left their mark on Indian history. The empire declined after the death of Aurangzeb in 1707. The empire formally ended a century and a half later, when power passed to the British crown after the great revolt of 1857.

At the height of its power the Mughal empire stretched from Afghanistan to Bengal and from Kashmir down to the Tamil region in the south. Mughal rule created a uniform, centralized administration over the entire country. The Mughals, especially Akbar, created a polity integrating Hindus and Muslims into a unified nation, forging a composite national identity. In addition, the Mughals left behind a heritage of great architecture, literature and art which has enriched India.

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